Root Cause Analysis (5 Whys) Template · Expert version

A root cause analysis template guides you from a problem to its underlying cause using the 5 whys, then to corrective actions with owners, so the problem does not come back.

How to use this template

1. Write a specific, factual problem statement.
2. Ask 'why?' and record the answer; repeat about five times.
3. Stop when you reach a cause you can act on.
4. Agree corrective actions with owners and dates.
5. Verify that the actions prevented recurrence.

Tips

• Base each answer on evidence.
• There may be several root causes: branch the analysis.
• Focus on processes, not people.
• For complex problems, use a fishbone diagram.

Dashboard (sample data)

Field	Value	Count
Type	Contain	0
Type	Correct	0
Type	Prevent	2
Owner	Ops lead	1
Owner	Scrum Master	1
Status	Not started	2
Status	In progress	0
Status	On hold	0
Status	Blocked	0
Status	Done	0

5 whys · Keep asking why until you reach a cause you can fix

Step	Question	Answer
Problem	What happened, where, when and how much?	Release 2.3 was delayed by 9 days
Why 1	Why did it happen?	Testing started late
Why 2	Why?	The test environment was not ready
Why 3	Why?	Environment requests were raised two days before testing
Why 4	Why?	Environment needs are not part of sprint planning
Why 5	Why?	There is no checklist for release prerequisites
Root cause	Summarise the root cause	No release prerequisites checklist in planning

Corrective actions · Fix the root cause, not just the symptom

Action	Type	Owner	Due date	How we will verify it worked	Status
Add environment readiness to sprint planning checklist	Prevent	Scrum Master	20 Mar 2026	Next 3 releases start testing on time	Not started
Book environments at release planning	Prevent	Ops lead	27 Mar 2026	Bookings logged 2 weeks ahead	Not started